

THE COURT THEATRE PRESENTS...

THEATRE SPORTS™

in schools

2024

Think fast.



Laugh last!

PERFORMERS' MANUAL



THE FIVE IMPROV COMMANDMENTS

1. I WILL REACT TO THE OFFERS I AM GIVEN
2. I WILL CREATE STORIES WORTH CARING ABOUT
3. I WILL MAKE OTHERS LOOK GOOD AHEAD OF MYSELF
4. I WILL BE BRAVE AND POSITIVE, EVEN WHEN I FAIL
5. I WILL PUT THE THEATRE IN THEATRESPORTS

Improvisation is unpredictable, exciting and often difficult to measure... but we promise that these principles will be at the heart of every great scene. These commandments are what the judges will be basing their scores on when your team is being scored.



THE COMPETITION FORMAT

MC WELCOME

The MC will welcome all the players to the stage and introduce the audience to Improvisation and prepare them for the show ahead.

WARMUP ROUND (OPTIONAL)

All players will be invited on to the stage to play a group game of Machine or Environments. This round is not scored. This is an opportunity to get to know the stage space and get ready for the next three rounds.

THE BLIND ROUND

Every improviser needs to know the basics. At random, you will be given a BLIND ROUND game which must be played immediately. Up to three minutes per scene.

CHOICE ROUND

You have up to three minutes. Your choice, take your pick from the Games section of the handbook.

CHALLENGE ROUND

You have up to three minutes for juniors and four minutes for seniors. One team makes a challenge to another team. The challenged team then plays the scene and are scored. Each team will have a challenge from a different team. You will need to share your challenges with the judges when you arrive for your heat and the Judges will choose which team challenges which.

TIE BREAKER ROUND

In the event of a tie for first place the two teams will compete in a round of Story, Story, Die!

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

HOW MANY PLAYERS CAN BE ON MY TEAM?

Each team may have **between three and six members**. We would suggest the best team size is four players. The judges highly recommend that no more than four players appear in any scene. However, your fifth and sixth players are welcome to provide scenery or sound effects or to become the MC, musician or narrator for your scene. We also want to see teams that represent the diversity of your school.

CAN A SCHOOL ENTER MORE THAN ONE TEAM?

Yes, for the 2024 Competition we will allow schools to enter more than one team, you must be prepared to play each other, and players must stick to the team they enter with, **players can't be swapped between teams**.

WHO IS JUNIOR/SENIOR?

Years 7-9 are JUNIOR, and Years 11-13 are SENIOR. Students in Year 10 may choose whether to compete in the JUNIOR or SENIOR competition but are only permitted to perform in one of these.

CAN WE MAKE UP A GAME OR PERFORM ONE WE FOUND ONLINE?

This is a lot of fun in workshops. For the competition, however, we recommend you play games from within this manual. There are two reasons for this:

- a) A lot of games described online are too simple or formulaic, which means they can't/won't let you demonstrate your mastery of the improv commandments, that will mean lower scores.
- b) The games featured in this manual have been selected because they are tried and tested, and when performed well we promise they will make your team look great.

If your team comes up with a great new game or you want to play a game not in the manual talk to us to seek approval.

IS THERE A 'CORRECT' WAY TO PLAY A GAME?

Teams are scored on how well they used improvisation skills (those are the IMPROV COMMANDMENTS) to perform their scenes, so you don't have to perform a game exactly the way every other team does.

Do make sure that you read the instructions for each game carefully. The judges have included a lot of tips for ensuring that your scene is as engaging and entertaining as possible.

DO PLAYERS HAVE TO BE THE SAME FOR THE HEATS AND FINAL?

Yes. But teams can play with a minimum of three if players are absent.

WHAT DOES THE MC DO?

The MC introduces teams, explains rules to the audience and keeps the competition running smoothly. The MC can be involved in certain games (eg. TIME JUMP, ACTOR SWITCH, etc.) although a player on your team is also allowed to perform this role.

IS THERE A PENALTY FOR FINISHING A SCENE EARLY?

None at all, the time limit isn't a target! In fact, scenes that find their natural ending early often score higher.

IN ROUNDS 2 & 3 CAN WE PLAY A GAME ANOTHER TEAM HAS ALREADY PLAYED?

You can but be aware, playing a game another team has already done can make it harder for your team to impress the judges (or the audience)! It's best to have a backup game (or two) up your sleeve. Talk to the judges/MC before the show about what games you want to play.

WHAT IS THE FORMAT FOR THE FINALS?

The finals for the Senior Theatresports Competition and the Junior Theatresports Competition are the same except for a time difference on the challenge round. Please read the manual carefully to ensure you are fully prepared.

WHAT HAPPENS IN THE EVENT OF A TIE FOR FIRST PLACE?

The teams tied will be asked to take part in a TIE BREAKER ROUND (Story, Story Die).

WHO CAN WATCH THE COMPETITION FOR FREE?

Members of your team who will be performing will not need to pay admission, nor will your team coach (limit of one). Tickets for all other audience members are a very small \$5 for under-25s and \$10 for everyone else. This is to help cover the costs of hiring the venue, gear and staff to run the competition. We will offer free tickets to the FINALS for anyone who performed in the competition. This is a great way to pick up some tips for next year.

WHEN SHOULD WE ARRIVE BEFORE OUR HEAT/FINAL?

Teams are called one hour prior, for warm-ups and briefing.

HOW CAN WE SEE THEATRESPORTS IN ACTION?

When possible, we will welcome Senior Teams to attend a performance of Scared Scriptless. Please contact education@courttheatre.org.nz to check availability for this offer.

TUTORING/ ENROLMENT

FEES FOR 2024

1 Team (Junior or Senior): \$250.00

2 Teams (Junior and/or Senior): \$460.00

3 Teams (Junior and/or Senior): \$630.00

4 Teams (Junior and/or Senior): \$720.00

All prices are exclusive of GST.

Schools may choose one session each for coaches, juniors, and senior teams. Junior coaches may choose both coaches session.

COACHING SESSIONS FOR 2024:

- Coach/Teacher Session 1 (Snr and Jnr): Wednesday 26th June, 4:30pm -6pm
- Coach/Teacher Session 2 (Jnr): Wednesday 23rd October, 4:30pm -6pm
- Senior Teams Session 1: Sunday 4th August, 1pm – 4pm
- Senior Teams Session 2: Sunday 11th August, 1pm – 4pm
- Junior Teams Session 1: Sunday 3rd November, 1pm – 4pm
- Junior Teams Session 2: Sunday 10th November, 1pm – 4pm

Schools who would like to receive additional improvisation training from The Court Jesters may arrange for in-school tutoring. Contact education@courttheatre.org.nz for more information.

A Court Jester can also be provided to run a Theatresports program at your school. Contact us for details.

DATES (HEATS AND FINALS)

SENIOR COMPETITION

HEATS

Venue Rangi Ruru Girls School

Dates:

Heat 1 - Saturday 31st August, 11am (10am performer call time)

Heat 2 - Saturday 31st August, 2pm (1pm performer call time)

Heat 3 - Saturday 31st August, 5pm (4pm performer call time)

Heat 4 - Sunday 1st September, 11am (10am performer call time)

Heat 5 - Sunday 1st September, 2pm (1pm performer call time)

Heat 6 - Sunday 1st September, 5pm (4pm performer call time)

SEMI-FINALS

A Semi-final will be held on the evening of **Sunday 8th September**

Venue: The Court Theatre

FINALS

Sunday 15th September, 6:30pm (5pm performer call time)

Venue: The Court Theatre Main Stage

NEW SENIOR COMPETITON AWARD

Introducing our new MVI (Most Valued Improvisor) Award –
The Cal Wilson MVI Award!



Clown Jewels (2023), a portrait of Cal Wilson by Andrea Huelin.

In honour of the incredible talent and indelible spirit of the beloved comedian and improv extraordinaire Cal Wilson, we are thrilled to announce a new award named in her memory. This award is dedicated to celebrating the life, laughter and enduring legacy of a talented artist who has made such a lasting impact on the Canterbury and New Zealand Improv scene.

Cal Wilson was a New Zealand stand-up comedian, author, television and radio presenter. She wrote the New Zealand sit com Willy Nilly from 2001 – 2003 and has appeared in numerous television and comedy shows both in New Zealand and Australia. In 1997 she was the inaugural winner of New Zealand's most prestigious comedy award, The Billy T Award. Cal was a co-founder of The Court Jesters in the early 90's and was a member of the New Zealand team that won the title at the World Theatresports Championship in Los Angeles in 1994. She was a pioneer of the New Zealand improv scene and credited her time in improv and as a Court Jester as being an amazing training ground, preparing her for future success. Cal Wilson passed away in 2023 after a brief battle with cancer at the age of 53. Her legacy will live on.

The Cal Wilson MVI award recipient will be selected from one of the teams competing in the Theatresports Final. The winner of the award will be decided by the three judges chosen to adjudicate the final in consultation with the MC for the final and The Court Theatre's Education and Outreach Manager. The recipient of this award will be the competitor who exemplifies the 5 improv commandments and embodies the fearless spirit of creativity Cal Wilson was renowned for.

The recipient will receive:

- The honour and recognition of receiving this award named after a legend of improv
- Public recognition through The Court Theatre and Court Education social media channels
- A scholarship for one of The Court Theatre Improv Education classes
- The opportunity to participate in a Court Jester workshop, learning from some of the best improvisors in the industry.

The Court Theatre would like to express its gratitude to Cal's husband Chris and mother Barbara, for their blessing in naming this award in Cal's honour.

JUNIOR COMPETITION

HEATS

Venue: Rangī Ruru Girls School

Dates:

Heat 1 - Saturday 23rd November, 11am (10am performer call time)

Heat 2 - Saturday 23rd November, 2pm (1pm performer call time)

Heat 3 - Saturday 23rd November, 5pm (4pm performer call time)

Heat 4 - Sunday 24th November, 11am (10am performer call time)

Heat 5 - Sunday 24th November, 2pm (1pm performer call time)

Heat 6 - Sunday 24th November, 5pm (4pm performer call time)

FINALS

Sunday 1st December, 6:30pm (5pm performer call time)

Venue: The Court Theatre Main Stage

NEW JUNIOR AWARD

The Junior Theatresports Rising Star Award!

At our competition, we've witnessed countless moments of brilliance, laughter, and camaraderie among our junior participants. From quick-thinking improvisations to hilarious character portrayals, our young performers never fail to impress with their imagination and enthusiasm. Now, with the introduction of the Junior Theatresports Rising Star Award, we aim to shine a spotlight on individuals who embody the spirit of innovation, teamwork, and potential that defines the essence of junior Theatresports.

Three winners of this award will be selected, one from the first day of heats, one from the second day of heats, and one from the final. The winners will be chosen by the judges, MC's and organisers of the competition.

The award recipients will receive:

- The recognition of their peers as a rising star and associated publicity
- A free Theatresports workshop the following year with a Court Jester at their school.

THEATRESPORTS JUDGES

The judges are twisted creatures who love giving out scores. Occasionally, during your scene, they will call out direction or advice. Don't stress about it. This is to help out your team, especially things like "speak up" or "make a positive offer" or "face the front".

THE TECHNIQUE JUDGE

This judge is all about the commandments. Make sure to obey all five, or there will be trouble.

POINTS: 1-5 points per scene. Half points may be given.

THE ENTERTAINMENT JUDGE

This judge enjoys the finer things in life. Give this judge entertaining scenes, playful attitudes and a great time, and your team will reap the rewards. They don't just like funny scenes, drama can be entertaining too.

POINTS: 1-5 points per scene. Half points may be given.

THE GUEST JUDGE

This judge will only appear at competition finals and acts according to their own capricious whims. They're looking for boldness, daring, flair, magic, and the unknown. Good luck.

POINTS: 1-5 points per scene. Half points may be given.

MAXIMUM AVAILABLE SCORE PER SCENE:

10 points, 15 if the Guest judge is in attendance.

WARM-UPS AND TIE-BREAKERS

All teams must be familiar with these three games as they are used for either onstage warm-ups or as deciders in the event of a tie for first place.

MACHINES

One by one the players step forward and, using a looping or repetitive physical gesture and sound, become the moving parts of an interconnected machine. The machine may build something specific - hats - or something more abstract like jealousy. The MC may speed up or slow down the machine.

TIPS: Look to create complimentary shapes and to make an interesting stage picture. While it is tempting to simply make a line, this is visually boring for an audience. Use different levels, angles and tempos to create variety.

ENVIRONMENTS

One by one the players step forward and create the various objects, creatures and characters that might be found in a named environment. They do not perform a scene but rather paint a living picture of a moment in a specific location. This may be a natural environment - under the sea - or a human environment, say a Library.

TIPS: Look to create complimentary offers to other people in the scene, rather than duplicating what already exists. If there's already an octopus maybe she needs more tentacles, or if there's some kelp perhaps it needs little fish swimming through it.

STORY STORY DIE

The Players stand in a line. The MC will sit in front of them and point at random players at random intervals. When they are pointed at they tell a story. As the MC switches the next player must seamlessly continue the story. If the player stutters, repeats a word, fails to make logical or grammatical sense, or in any other way fumbles the story the audience will eliminate them from the game by shouting "DIE!" The Judges and the MC will make the final decision about who is eliminated.

If players are too good at this the MC or judges may make it more difficult by saying that using a specific word, e.g. 'and', is also cause for elimination, or even that using a specific letter is forbidden.

The last player remaining wins.

BLIND ROUND - 3 MINUTES

Your team will be randomly given one of the games in the BLIND ROUND list to play. These games were selected because, as a group, they cover the essential improvisation skills.

POEM

(Quick thinking/confidence) Your challenge is to improvise a poem. In rhyme. You may choose to tell a story, or to describe a person or event. Your team can choose your favourite rhyme scheme... as long as there is one.

TIPS: Stick to a rhythm. Good poems make sense and build on the offers that came before. Know that when your brain does fail you — as it does everyone — confidence will sell everything. You're improvising poetry, after all.

YES AND EXPERTS

(Accepting offers, advancing) You and a partner, as fellow experts, have been invited to share your knowledge on a particular subject. Every statement you make must build on and support what your fellow 'expert' has just said.

TIPS: Take turns making statements, and keep them short. The game is less about what is said than the struggle between two actors forced to agree with each other. Give eye contact and concentrate on the last statement your partner made — this will help you create a narrative that delights and escalates. It can be fun to make crazy statements, knowing your partner must say 'Yes! And...', but take your time and stay logical. The audience will be much more satisfied if they followed all the steps that got you from teaspoons to radioactive bats in tutus.

SHARED STORY / SHARED STYLE STORY

(Storytelling, genres) As a team, take turns telling your audience a satisfying story. SENIOR teams may play this as SHARED STYLE STORY, in which performers must each take a contrasting genre (style of film or book) to influence the way they deliver their parts of the story.

TIPS: Whatever your subject matter, really focus on the second commandment: "I will create stories worth caring about". Give your characters details and aspirations, and make sure we have enough information to care that they achieve these. Use your voice to tell the story, think about how you use pace, volume and emotion. If playing SHARED STYLE STORY, make sure your genres don't destroy the story. Think about how you could describe a person running in a variety of different genres. Do you prefer to describe her golden flowing hair, or do you focus on her rate of acceleration?



TOP TIP

Try reading the poem "The Night Before Christmas". Notice the pattern. As a team choose a pattern to structure your poem.

WORD AT A TIME

(Yielding, physicality) For two actors. Your challenge is to act out a story while speaking alternate words. Imagine you have been combined to become a single person: "Walking... through... the... woods... I... saw..."

TIPS: This game was invented to stop actors pre-planning. Everything your partner says is 100% correct, even when it isn't what you would have said. Go with it. Make eye contact. Be brave. Act out what you are describing, and if there is nothing to act, make bolder choices. This game flies when performers delight each other, but dies when they try to be 'correct'.

Stage Directions

(Yielding, advancing. Previously known as He said/She said) Two players will perform a scene. When player A finishes a line of dialogue, player B will first provide a stage direction, then deliver his or her own line.

EXAMPLE: A: "Nice to meet you" B: "She said, entering my office" (A enters B's office) "Lie down on this bed and tell me what's wrong." A: "He said, shuffling away from me and hiding behind the curtain." (B does this) "You don't look very confident, doctor..." B: "She said, approaching me and standing uncomfortably close..." A: "I'm afraid of patients!"

TIPS: This game is all about pace. Use the stage directions to move the story into the future. There is no point in describing what the audience has already seen. Focus on delighting your partner, and building on his or her energy. Interact whenever possible. (eg. "He said, throwing ME a spanner", rather than "He said, picking up a spanner"). Be joyful and a little cheeky. Put yourselves in trouble:

A: "He said, arresting me." (B handcuffs A) "But I'm your headmistress!" B: "She said, bursting into a flood of tears. "Now you've wet my best sneakers, Mrs Thompson!" etc.

Teams may choose to play with two actors performing and another two providing stage directions.

SPEAK IN ONE VOICE

Three or four players will answer interview questions from another player or the MC, speaking simultaneously as if they were one person.

TIPS: The game can be deceptively difficult because what makes it funny is actually the potential for failure. Audiences love watching you struggle bravely together and will be delighted even if/when you occasionally don't make sense. Be courageous and resist the urge to play things safe by leading your team-mates or pre-planning answers.

CHOICE ROUND - 3 MINUTES

In round two of the competition teams can play any game or scene from the GAMES List. Simple as that. Play to your strengths.

THE GAMES

ACTOR'S NIGHTMARE

One actor on your team is handed pages of a script to read from and a page is selected at random. Everything they say must come from this. The challenge and humour comes from the justification the other players must do in order to make sense of these lines.

TIPS: Make your script holder the main character, and also make her important as the script reader, don't worry about finding the best line or one that 'makes sense'. Say the next line and see what happens! The other characters need a reason to make sense of what the script-holder says, so understand that it is more fun to endow her as a queen than to dismiss her as a madman and ignore her.

ACTOR SWITCH

When the MC calls 'switch' all on stage actors must jump into the character of the actor next to them when the MC calls 'switch' (rotate clockwise).

TIPS: The humour of this scene comes from the energy and contrasts. Set up clearly defined big characters — otherwise switching between them will be no fun.

ALPHABET

Perform a scene in which every line of dialogue must begin with the next letter in the alphabet.

TIPS: Have fun with this game. The letter restriction is there to spark your imagination. See what happens when you say the first thing that comes to your head, while aiming to maintain a clear story line.

BALLET

Musician recommended. Players improvise a ballet. One player may choose to narrate the ballet, or alternatively all players may take the stage. Players may choose to tell an original tale or to stage an existing story/film as a ballet.

TIPS: Be courageous. Fill the stage... make it interesting to watch. Your energy, creativity and teamwork will sell this game. Understand that the audience will have more fun seeing you commit to the style than watching you do a deliberately sloppy job.

ENGLISH/GIBBERISH SWITCH

A scene is performed, whenever the MC calls ‘switch’ the actors must switch between English and Gibberish (made up language)

TIPS: Gibberish frees players up to make big physical and emotional offers. Use these to advance your scene. Let your audience delight in your energy and justifications.

FILM REVIEW

Two studio experts discuss and review an upcoming blockbuster movie. The other two players will perform short snippets from this movie.

TIPS: Think about the language movie reviewers might use. Give lots of specific details. Players performing scenes from the movie have equal responsibility for telling the story, so do not just re-enact what has already been described by the reviewers. Think about the consequences of what has happened in the previous scene.

GENRE AUDITION

Your team asks the audience for a fairytale, and then each individual player will also get a movie genre. Players are called out one-by-one by the MC (or your fifth or sixth player) to audition for roles in this fairytale, but their audition will be done in their particular genre – as if this is the only type of acting they know how to do.

TIPS: The MC will ask you which scene and character in the fairytale you would like to audition with. Choose ones which will complement your chosen character; eg. an action movie star may have fun playing Cinderella in the scene in which the clock strikes midnight and she must flee the ball.

GENRE ROLLERCOASTER

Perform a single scene, but at any point the MC may call out a new genre. The entire scene must immediately switch to this style.

TIPS: The fun of this scene is in the changes. Make them snappy. Focus on keeping the storyline clear. Sci-fi, for example, doesn’t always need you to introduce spaceships... think instead how characters might act/talk/walk/interact in different genres. It can be fun to play minor or background characters.

GENRE SCENE

Use your team’s knowledge of a particular genre to perform an open scene in this style. Popular examples are Shakespeare scene, western scene, sci fi scene or a melodrama scene.

TIPS: Only ask the audience for genre suggestions if you are confident in a variety of genres. You are welcome to choose a genre beforehand, and then say, for example, “We are going to perform a scene in the style of a modern romantic comedy.” Be aware that the audience and judges will be looking for signs of

preplanning, so ensure you take a suitably open ask-for. For example, if performing a Western, do not announce, “This will be set in a saloon. What is something they will be drinking?” Ask for something broader, such as an occupation or location.

GOOD DAY/BAD DAY

The MC will ask an audience member for the things he or she did today (or yesterday.) Play it as the worst day ever, and then the best day ever. One minute and thirty seconds per scene.

TIPS: Being respectful and generous to your audience member is your top priority. Always portray them in a fair light, even in the ‘bad’ scene. Bad things can happen to people, without them being nasty people themselves. This game is not as easy as it might seem; because it has such a formula judges will really be looking for listening, intelligent observation and great use of the ‘improv commandments’.

HALF LIFE

Players perform a 60 second scene, which is then replayed in 30 seconds, then 15, then 7.5, then 3, then 1 second.

TIPS: Make things happen in the first scene!

MEANWHILE

Your team performs a scene split between two locations, calling “meanwhile” at any time to switch between them.

TIPS: Each time you come back to a scene, some time should have passed. It can be narratively satisfying to the audience if you can manage to link the scenes — either by having the scenes come together, or finding a thematic link between the two.

NEW CHOICE

Scene is played out with an MC or player watching from the wings or on a chair at the side of the stage. When that person hears a verbal offer they want to change, they will call “New choice!”. The player in question must then immediately change their offer. The person calling the changes may keep changing the offers until they are satisfied with the offer. When they have finished their intervention(s) the scene continues as normal. E.g. I got you these flowers! (New choice!) I got you these chocolates! (New choice!) I got you this exchange student. (Scene carries on)

TIPS: Players should allow extreme changes to change the direction of the scene. Play the new reality as truly as possible. Players have the habit of saying ‘new choice’ twice and then accepting the third idea. Try for variety.

OPEN SCENE

All other games described in this manual have a ‘handle’. These are rules that the audience enjoy seeing you have to obey. An open scene has none, you simply improvise a scene, allowing you to take it wherever you wish.

TIPS: Whatever ask-for you accept, be open to the offers coming from your teammates. “Yes! And...” everything. See where the story goes. You are encouraged to use the improv storytelling techniques found in other games to help create a satisfying scene — think techniques such as calling “meanwhile” or using tag-outs.

PAPERS

Players perform a scene, but at any point may pick up a paper containing a line of dialogue. They must deliver this immediately, and then justify it in the scene.

TIPS: Don’t progress your scene until you have justified what the line of dialogue meant. Challenge yourselves not to pre-justify your lines (eg. by saying “my father always says...” before reading a paper) — doing so makes the game less fun to watch! Read your paper as soon as you’ve picked it up and give these lines of dialogue real importance. Try having emotional reactions to what is read out. Be aware of when people pick up a paper, and make sure to let them speak immediately. Once you’ve read a paper, put it in your pocket. If you drop it on the floor, another player might pick it up and read the same line again. The MC will prepare lines for your team to use (warn the MC before the competition).

POP-UP STORY BOOK

Three or four players lie on the stage, heads towards the audience. A narrator stands and crosses the stage, lifting up the imaginary page of a large book. As he or she does so, the players pop up, as in a children’s book. The narrator tells a story as if reading it from the page, justifying what the players are doing.

TIPS: Be still! Pop up instantly. Part of the joy of this game is the justification the narrator needs to do. Don’t make your narrator’s job too easy (or hard)! Experiment with bringing the pop-up storybook to life by pulling action tabs and pressing voice buttons, but don’t use these too much.

PUPPETS

Players performing this scene are unable to move their bodies. Two members of the team are puppeteers, responsible for controlling all players’ movement. The puppets provide the dialogue, the puppeteers the movement.

variation: **TORTURE PUPPETS**

In this variation only one player is the puppeteer and is ‘tortured’ by the others having to move all other players by themselves.

TIPS: It can take a lot of concentration to be a ‘puppet’. Only move when the puppeteer is controlling you. Keep your head still — if you are not looking at your scene partner, it is the puppeteer’s job to move your head for you. Be gentle as a puppeteer, and never force or push your fellow players.

RADIO PLAY

With the stage lights turned down, your team performs an episode of a radio play.

TIPS: Decide on the genre of your play, and make sure your team listens to some real examples. Are you doing a 1950s adventure serial, or a modern Radio New Zealand domestic drama? This game allows you to present situations and characters which could otherwise be very difficult to perform — take advantage of this.

REPLAY SCENE

A one minute scene is performed, and then replayed in two contrasting styles. For example, a trip to the salon is replayed first as a film noir, then as a soap opera.

TIPS: This game needs an interesting first scene. Make things happen! Create confident characters with strong attitudes and relationships.

SHAKESPEARE

Perform a scene in the style of a William Shakespeare play.

TIPS: Think about the themes and plot devices Shakespeare used; more happened in his plays than just murders. Plot devices can make for interesting ask-fors. Similes and soliloquies will add authenticity. Ensure your team understands the rules of you/thee/thou etc.

SIT, STAND, LIE

At all times, one player onstage must be sitting, one lying down, and one standing. If another player moves position, the other performers must adjust their physicality to ensure everyone is different. This only applies to onstage players.

TIPS: The humour comes from people's changing physicality contrasted against the scene being played. Be snappy with your movements. Remember that audiences like scenes to build up — don't go crazy at the start of a scene and exhaust everyone. Don't worry about justifying the changes in physicality - otherwise it will just be a scene about people falling over.

SLIDE SHOW

A player presents a series of snapshots from a recent trip or event. The other players become the photos, freezing in position for each one.

TIPS: Make sure players remain still. As with Pop-Up Storybook, don't change position if your storyteller's description doesn't match what is in your own head. Storytellers must explain everything they see. Give your scene lots of good, basic details at the start. These will be invaluable later on.

SLO-MO COMMENTARY

TIPS: Have fun with the genre. Think about the passion, knowledge and experience sports commentators have for their particular sports, and bring all of this to the game. The humour comes from making something mundane exciting

— so understand that it is not the slo-mo performer’s job to be interesting. Look at the skills professional commentators use to keep audiences’ energy up, even when very little is happening. The judges have seen a lot of scenes where the competitors end up fighting – see if you can find a unique way to play this game to surprise and excite the judges

SONG

Players improvise a song, in any style. Because musos are not provided at all competition dates, we suggest teams choose this only if they are able to accompany themselves (guitar, ukulele, beat boxing...)

VARIATION: Da Doo Ron Ron. (This can be played without accompaniment). Players improvise a song using the format of the song ‘Da Doo Ron Ron’, retaining the same rhyme scheme (AABBB) as the original. Players may choose to switch position at the end of each verse, sharing the responsibility for rhyming around.

TIPS: Ensure that you obey the improv commandments, even when performing a song. Sing like you know all the words off by heart.

SONG CUE

Musician recommended. Teams perform a game, but after any line the MC may call “song cue”. Players must immediately improvise a song with this title.

TIPS: It can be a challenge to create satisfying songs that don’t peter out. Think of ways you could use the line to inspire interesting lyrics — you don’t just have to repeat the line endlessly, or sing the dialogue your character had been about to deliver. Short songs are fine.

SUBTITLES/BLIND DUBBING

Two players perform a scene in gibberish – a made up nonsense language. The other two performers stand to the side of the stage, and provide translations after each player’s line.

VARIATION: Dubbing. The actors perform their scene as if muted, while one or two actors provide their dialogue.

VARIATION: Blind Dubbing. Like dubbing but the actors providing the voices can’t see the actor on stage. Have them sit at front of stage with their backs to the scene.

TIPS: Be playful with your fellow improvisers. Watch out for subtitles becoming either too ‘straight’ (ie repeating what has just been shown on stage) or too bizarre.

TAG-OUT SCENE

Two players start a scene, but a third player may at any time run in and tag one of the performers out. The player who was not replaced maintains his or her character, but we now see this person in a new time or place. Characters may be

brought back multiple times, and players may perform several different roles (make them different and clear).

TIPS: Experiment with using tag-outs in a variety of ways. They can move the storyline forward, or be used for comic effect (eg. we see a clumsy employee fired from three different jobs in quick succession). The game does not necessarily need to follow one main character, but you may find that this will help you create a story worth caring about.

TIME JUMP

Players perform a scene, but at any time the MC may announce a jump in time (eg. “three years later” or “five minutes earlier”).

TIPS: Although the MC will be helping you by announcing the jumps in time, do not see this as an easy way out. The judges will be looking out for bold choices, a cohesive storyline, and use of the improv commandments.

TROUBADOUR

Musician required One player, the Singer, can accompany themselves by guitar other instrument. They sing a narration to a scene while the others perform it.

TIPS: The Singer is there to guide the narrative, but make sure the other players share responsibility for the scene. The Singer should not sing for the whole scene — she may choose to be silent for periods, resuming singing only to advance the story. This game is similar in form to Typewriter.

TYPEWRITER

One player types a novel, reading aloud as it is written. The other players become the characters in the novel. Once the scene has begun the typist only needs to narrate occasionally.

TIPS: Make sure to share the storytelling responsibility. Play with the rules of this game. If the typist has the power to write the story, they also have the power to edit it...a great trick to help get a story back on track.

YEARBOOK

Take from the audience an unusual club or hobby. With the lights down, players arrange themselves into a frozen ‘yearbook photo’. When lights come up, they take turns talking about their particular club, focusing on a particular event that happened that year.

TIPS: Adding detail at the beginning of the scene will be invaluable later. Does everyone have a name? When does the club meet, and how do meetings run? Experiment with possible storylines... Yearbook scenes don’t need to end in fighting.

CHALLENGE ROUND

3 MINUTES JUNIORS | 4 MINUTES SENIORS

In the final round each team will challenge another team to perform a scene that incorporates a challenge they set. The order of who challenges who will be set by either the Judges or MC.

Challenges are there to inspire you as well as to showcase another level of skill. The judges and the MC will check with you prior to the final to find out what your challenge will be. If you're having trouble coming up with one the judges or MC will be able to help you.

In the past we have advocated for thematic challenges. Our experience of this has been moralistic scenes that don't explore the inherent playfulness of improvisation. This year we will be looking for challenges that offer specific but simple content additions.

- A scene with a cake
- A scene where someone falls down a hole
- A scene with a bee in it

Challenges that are deemed unlikely to succeed, against the spirit of the competition or ill-advised will be vetoed by the judges. Think about a challenge that you would find inspiring and that is likely to work with most games. The team that receives the challenge may get a further ask-for if they wish.

Teams are able to use any format or game from the competition, including open scenes, to perform their challenge. The scenes will be scored out of five by each judge and as well as fulfilling the improv commandments the judges will be looking to see how well the team incorporated their challenge.

TECHNIQUE #1 - YES AND

I WILL REACT TO THE OFFERS I AM GIVEN

Because you only get one shot at the scene you are performing, everything is 100% correct. The line of dialogue your teammate just delivered was the perfect thing to say. The character who tripped over as he crossed the stage was supposed to do that. The emotion your scene partner just expressed affects you in a particular way.

To be free and ready to say “Yes! And...” is the easiest thing in the world, but it can feel scary and unnatural. It requires you to pay absolute attention. You cannot pre-plan. All you see are the choices — deliberate or otherwise — that have come before in the scene, and all your brain thinks about are what the next immediate consequences of these might be.

STOP PRE-PLANNING. THAT’S SCRIPT WRITING. THIS IS IMPROV

If the baddie shoots you, don’t delay your death for a minute as you search for a witty line. Accept that you’ve been shot (yes) and die (and). Your character’s death becomes the offer your teammates will now “Yes! And...” themselves.

“Yes! And...” can sometimes lead to letting go of what your character previously wanted or believed. Don’t be afraid to let your characters change, react and grow.

LASTLY, SOMETIMES SAYING YES MEANS SAYING NO

Let’s explain: A: (Thief bursts through door) “Give me all your valuables!” B: “Oh okay, here they are.” ALTERNATIVELY, C: “No, mother. This is the last time you will rob us!”

Note that both B and C accept the offer, even though C says “no”.

Keith Johnstone says: “Improv takes place in the present tense.” “The actor who will accept anything that happens seems supernatural.”

TECHNIQUE #2 – NARRATIVE

Just because you're improvising doesn't mean the audience should suffer through pointless scenes. However, this often happens when performers get worried about their scene not being entertaining enough. Players become zany and loud in an effort to be 'interesting', or concentrate so hard on 'acting' that nothing happens. Instead...

ASK YOURSELF WHY YOUR CHARACTER CARES SO MUCH

If your ask-for was "shoelace", and you now find your characters squabbling pointlessly over a missing pair of laces, take a breath. Why are the shoe laces important to your character? Do you need them for a big job interview? If so, why is the other character trying to stop you getting the job? Are they jealous? In general, avoid making the scene about the 'thing' – make it about what's going on between the people.

STORIES COME FROM ROUTINES BEING BROKEN

Teaching, arguing or making a transaction is tempting, because suddenly players feel safe and in control. It feels like 'real acting'. It's also boring to watch! Break the routine, move the action forward. You may like to look at the story chairs technique that offers a classic structure to stories to give you a narrative guide (this is the structure of most Pixar films).

RECYCLE

Lastly, audiences need to feel there is a 'point' to things. If they learn at the start of the scene that your character is a talented knitter they will assume this is important to the story — and so will keep thinking about it. If it doesn't feature again they will lose trust in your ability to tell a satisfying tale and their attention may begin to wander. Think always about tying up the threads of your story. Give your audiences that content feeling that comes when every mystery has been solved... when every box has been ticked. This is called reincorporation.

I WILL CREATE STORIES WORTH CARING ABOUT

Keith Johnstone says: "A alters B — that's drama."

TECHNIQUE #3 - TEAMWORK

I WILL MAKE OTHERS LOOK GOOD AHEAD OF MYSELF

Great improvisation requires great teamwork.

WHOSE STORY IS IT?

Nothing looks worse than a scene in which actors don't know their place. If your team is improvising a romantic comedy and actors #1 and #2 have already set themselves up as the sympathetic romantic leads, don't come on and try to be an even better romantic lead... no matter how gorgeous you think you are. Your teammates need you to be the bad girl! (Not the bad girl who ultimately gets the boy, but the bad girl who loses in the end!)

BE WILLING TO CHANGE

As an improviser you will occasionally find yourself in situations where your scene partner has a different understanding of what your roles are. If changing your character won't destroy what has already happened in your scene, then do so — happily and quickly. Rolling your eyes and pointing out what a bad listener the other improviser is will only make you both look bad.

HOW CAN I IMPROVE WHAT'S ALREADY HERE?

In any scene, think about who your fellow characters are. Is the lead female in this scene a charming lady with a crippling fear of plants? Your characters will add to the story by creating plant-related situations to test her. If your team-mate is in a high-status role but struggles to make brave choices on stage, think about how your characters can back him up and assist the story without stealing the limelight.

Keith Johnstone says: "It should be an act of benevolence when you improvise."

TECHNIQUE #4 - LOSING THE FEAR

I WILL BE BRAVE AND POSITIVE, EVEN WHEN I FAIL

Life teaches people to plan ahead, and to make safe choices. Perhaps that's why improvisation can be so thrilling. Understand that many Theatresports games have restrictions which make things look harder, but actually help you to make brave improv choices.

YOU ARE SAFER THAN YOU REALISE

To the audience, teams are the heroes and the judges are the baddies. A bad score will be the judges' fault. ALWAYS hold your head up high, and be courageous, confident and playful performers.

REVEAL THINGS

Many beginning improvisers are so scared of 'revealing' their thoughts to the audience that they avoid being specific. Who and where are you? Any choice is correct — don't wait until you know where the story is going before you define things. Understand that fear of making decisions might make you say nonsense things (being 'random' feels safer), or to improvise about obscure topics (in order to appear intelligent). This just makes it harder for your team to craft a satisfying story. The audience will ALWAYS prefer a clear, specific scene.

FINALLY...

Some people give up on improv after being in scenes that don't go well. Who cares?! The audience love you for showing them you're human! Stay positive, and instead of blaming yourself or others, think only about the choices you made. You're a good improviser, but maybe you forgot the first improv commandment in that scene.

Keith Johnstone says: "Don't be perfect. Make mistakes and then you're more interesting to an audience."

TECHNIQUE #5 - PUT ON A SHOW

I WILL PUT THE THEATRE IN THEATRESPOITS

You may have heard the phrase “own the stage”. This means to perform on stage as confidently as if it were your own home. If audiences feel you are in control, they will relax and have fun watching your scene. If they see scared looking improvisers they may be too concerned to fully enjoy your scene, or worse, might assume that you don’t know what you’re doing and lose interest.

BE VOCALLY AND PHYSICALLY ADAPTABLE

This is your easiest way to own the stage. Are you playing the bad guy? Use a booming voice, take huge strides and enter from the back of the stage. Is your next character a nervous wreck? Imagine that your knees don’t work and you have to clutch at furniture just to stay upright. These choices create theatre, and are much more interesting than yet another scene featuring four teens standing in a line, talking!

CREATE PHYSICAL ENVIRONMENTS FOR SCENES

This comes back to being specific. You don’t have to go crazy miming everything in your environment, but understand that every detail you add will help your fellow performers — and the audience — better understand what’s going on.

BE SMART AND PROFESSIONAL AT ALL TIMES

A nicely-dressed, happy and confident team is more likely to be forgiven for an unsatisfying scene than a scruffy, negative team avoiding eye contact. Ensure that your teammates wear clothing that won’t restrict, distract or reveal too much.

Keith Johnstone says: “The voice is not just to be heard, it’s a whip that disciplines the spectators. Be dynamic!”

ASK-FORS: A HOW TO GUIDE

Every scene needs something to inspire it. In Theatresports matches, we get suggestions from the audience before every scene. Doing this involves the crowd, as well as reminding them that you are indeed making it up! JUNIOR teams will be given an ask-for via the MC, while SENIOR teams will be encouraged to ask the audience directly.

TIPS There is no perfect ask-for. Honestly. See if you can craft a great scene from a random word in the dictionary.

One ask-for per scene is all you should need.

The audience will think they have to give you crazy suggestions, not realising that this makes it harder to deliver a satisfying scene. Delight them by crafting mundane suggestions into interesting stories.

Try not to crack any jokes about your ask-for before the scene. You might be ruining an opportunity for laughter later.

Your ask-for helps you start the scene — not end it. If you take ‘lab rat’, introduce one immediately.

Take suggestions your whole team understands. You get no points for being clever. List jobs, hold objects, domestic tasks, relationships between two people.

Very vague ask-fors such as ‘a colour’ can be difficult to base a scene on, since they don’t give players much to work with.

Before the competition, test your ask-fors on other people. If they can’t think of two or three examples easily, neither will the audience.

You don’t have to use the ask-for in the most obvious way. If you get ‘dentist’ you needn’t start your scene sitting in the chair.

You can give a couple of examples of what you’re looking for. e.g. We’d like a location, like a museum or a hospital.

We will not accept ask-fors from your friends or other teams. The judges also look out for signs of pre-planning in scenes. Don’t think you can cheat your way through improv — the greatest improvisers prepare nothing.

Dan Bain (Former Artistic Director of The Court Jesters) says: “Just jump. Assemble your parachute on the way down.”

IDEAS OF ASK FORS

Locations:

Bank
Museum
Italian Restaurant
Playground
Art Gallery
Factory that makes X
Tunnels
Basement
Driving School
Candy store
Courtroom
Graveyard
Library
Campsite
Hotel
Boxing Ring
Sleepover
Airport
Driveway
Stable
Desert

Relationships:

Lawyer/client
Father/son
Doctor/patient
Beauty therapist/client
Uncle-aunt/niece-nephew
Zookeeper/Parrot
Director/Movie star
Wizard/Apprentice
Baker/Customer
Teacher/Student
Flight Attendant/Passenger

Occupations:

Carpenter
Teacher
Fire Fighter
Truck driver
Doctor
Dance teacher
Lawyer
Politician
Janitor
Singer
Farmer
Mailperson
Accountant
Astronaut
Influencer

Objects:

Lawnmower
Blender
Golf Club
diamond necklace
Pizza
Kitten Harness
Safe
Ice cream
Target
Grammy
Mattress
Comic Book
Glasses
Shovel
Key
Helmet
Pie

FURTHER READING

IMPRO: IMPROVISATION AND THE THEATRE by Keith Johnstone **IMPRO FOR STORYTELLERS** by Keith Johnstone **THEATRESPORTS DOWNUNDER** by Lyn Pierse
IMPROV: SCENE FROM THE INSIDE OUT by Mick Napier

THE IMPROV HANDBOOK by Deborah Frances-White and Tom Salinsky

www.improvincyclopedia.org

www.unexpectedproductions.org/living_playbook.htm

www.dangoldstein.com/howtoimprovise.html www.yesand.com

And finally, understand that even the greatest improvisers are still learning.

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Additional Content and Amendments by Ben O'Brien-Limmer

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